Madurai

Madurai has been one of the oldest cities in India. Its antiquity can be understood from the sobriquet "Sangam Valartha Nagaram" it has earned.

Pandyas, the Cholas and later the Kalabras ruled Madurai in the ancient period. During medieval times, later Cholas and later Pandyas followed by the Nayaks ruled this historic town. This has resulted in cultural blending. Trade flourished and evidence for this has been unearthed in archaeological excavation done in Keezhadi near Madurai.

Madurai is proudly associated with tamil sangam (academies), which worked for the promotion of Tamil language. Forty-nine poets were associated with the last Sangam. Ahil, fragrant wood, was brought from Port Thondi to Madurai. King Solomon of ancient Israel imported pearls from Uvari near the Pandyan port, Korkai.



A mint of Roman coins was present at Madurai. The coins of other countries were also minted at Madurai, which is a proof for the glory of Madurai.

The fame of Madurai is attested by the accounts of the Greek historian Megasthanese. Chanakya, Chandragupta's minister, makes a mention of Madurai in his book, *Arthasastra*.

In the moat around the town, tunnels had been constructed in such a way that even elephants could comfortably enter.

Thoonga Nagaram



Madurai had Naalangadi and Allangadi.

Naalangadi – Day Market.

Allangadi – Evening Market.

Madurai is known as Thoonga Nagaram (the city that never sleeps). Madurai was a safe place where women purchased things from Allangadi without any fear.

Kanchi

A place of learning is called school. Several schools were established in great numbers for the first time in Kancheepuram. Jains studied in *Jainapalli*, and Buddhists studied in Viharas.

The greatness of Kanchi as an educational centre can be understood from the fact that the Chinese traveller Hieun Tsang who studied at Nalanda

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